Vivid Verbs

Concept

Choose verbs that name the action precisely. A strong verb helps the reader see movement, intention or reasoning.

Precision over decoration

Strolled, sprinted and staggered all describe movement, but imply different speed or condition.

Meaning first

Substitute only when the new verb expresses the intended action.

Tense and grammar

Keep tense consistent and check whether the verb needs an object or a preposition.

Academic verbs

Analyzes, suggests, contrasts and demonstrates describe different analytical actions.

Reference bank

Alphabetical inventory from the supplied handout. Repeated entries are consolidated; mixed tense forms are retained.

Vivid Verbs

Example 1 | original model

Revise: She went across the room quickly.

Solution / why it works

1. Ask how she moved: urgently, playfully or awkwardly?
2. Urgent: She dashed across the room.
3. Awkward: She stumbled across the room.
4. These versions change the meaning; choose the one supported by the scene.

Word bank | A

abandon	achieve	affect
abduct	acknowledge	agonize
abolish	acquire	agree
abscond	act	agreed
absorb	activate	aid
abuse	adapt	aim
accelerate	add	alarm
accept	address	align
access	adjust	allege
accommodate	administer	alleviate
accomplish	admit	allocate
accost	admonish	allow
account for	advance	alter
accrue	advertise	amble
accumulate	advise	amend
accuse	advocate	amplify

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | A (continued)

amuse
analyze
annihilate
announce
answer
anticipate
appear
apply
appoint
appraise
appreciate
apprehend
approach
approve
approximate
arbitrate
argue
arise
arrange
arrest
articulate
ascend
ascertain
assault
assemble
assent
assert
assess
assign
assist
associate
assume
assure
attack
attain
attend
attract
attribute
audit
augment
author
authorize
automate
avert
avoid
avow
awaken
award

Word bank | B

babble
baffle
bang
bank
banter
bar
bark
bargain
barrel
bawl
beam
beat
beg
began
begin
behave
believe
bellow
benefit
bequeath
berate
bereave
bestow
bind
bite
blame
blast
block
blot
blow

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | B (continued)

blur
boast
bolster
bolt
bombard
bond
boogie
boost
bound
brag
brandish
break
breed
bribe
brief
broaden
buck
budge
budget
bug out
build
bully
bump
burrow
bury
bushwhack

Word bank | C

cackle
cajole
calculate
calibrate
canter
canvass
capitalize
capture
care
careen
carry
catalog
catapult
catch
categorize
cater
cause
cede
center
centralize
chair
challenge
chant
characterize
charge
charm
chart
chase
chastise
chatter
check
choke
choose
chuck
circle
circulate
claim
clamor
clarify
clash
classify
climb
clinch
clip
clutch
coach
coalesce
coddle
code
coerce
collaborate

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | C (continued)

collapse
collar
collate
collect
collide
collude
combat
combine
comfort
command
commandeer
commence
comment
communicate
compare
compete
compile
complain
complete
complicate
compose
compress
compute
conceive
concentrate
conceptualize
conciliate
conclude
concoct
concur
condense
conduct
confer
confess
confide
confine
confirm
conjecture
connect
conquer
conserve
consider
consolidate
constitute
constrain
construct
construe
consult
contact
continue
contort
contract
contradict
contrast
contribute
control
converge
convert
convey
convince
cooperate
coordinate
copy
corner
correct
correlate
correspond
corroborate
counsel
count
crab
cram
crash
crawl
create
creep
cripple
critique
croon
crouch
cruise
crush
cultivate
customize

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | D

dance	depart	dig
dart	depict	diminish
dash	deploy	direct
dawdle	deposit	disagree
deal	depreciate	disarm
debase	derive	discard
debate	descend	discharge
debug	describe	disclose
decide	desecrate	discover
deck	design	discriminate
declare	designate	discuss
decline	destroy	dismiss
decode	detail	dispatch
decrease	detect	disperse
dedicate	deter	display
deduce	deteriorate	disprove
defend	determine	disrupt
defer	develop	dissect
define	deviate	disseminate
deflect	devise	dissociate
deify	devote	dissolve
delegate	devour	distinguish
delineate	diagnose	distribute
deliver	diagram	disturb
demand	dictate	ditch
demonstrate	differ	dive
denounce	differentiate	diverge
deny	diffuse	diversify

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | D (continued)

divert
divide
divulge
document
dodge
dominate
dope
douse
draft
drag
drain
dramatize
drape
drawl
dress
dribble
drift
drill
drink
drip
drive
drone
drool
drop
drove
drown
drug
duel
dunk
duplicate
dwell

Word bank | E

earn
ease
edge
edify
edit
educate
effect
eject
elaborate
elect
elevate
elicit
eliminate
elongate
elope
elucidate
elude
emanate
embody
emerge
emit
emphasize
employ
enable
encapsulate
encompass
encourage
end
endure
enforce
engage
engender
engineer
engorge
enhance
enjoin
enlarge
enlighten
enlist
enrage
enrapture
enrich
ensnare
ensure
entail

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | E (continued)

enter
entertain
entreat
enumerate
enunciate
equip
eradicate
err
erupt
escalate
escape
escort
establish
estimate
evacuate
evade
evaluate
evaporate
evict
evidence
evolve
exacerbate
examine
except
exchange
excite
exclaim
exclude
execute
exemplify
exercise
exert
exhale
exhibit
exist
exit
expand
expedite
expel
experience
experiment
explain
explode
exploit
explore
expose
express
extend
extract
extrapolate
extricate
exude

Word bank | F

fabricate
facilitate
fade
fail
fake
fall
falsify
falter
familiarize
fan
fashion
fast
father
fear
feature
feed
feel
fend
fetch
fight
filch
file
fill
filter

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | F (continued)

finalize
finance
find
fine tune
finger
finish
fit
fix
flag
flap
flash
flatten
flatter
flaunt
flay
flee
flick
flinch
fling
flip
flirt
flit
float
flog
flounder
flout
flow
flung
flush
flutter
fly
focus
follow
fondle
forage
force
forecast
foretold
form
formulate
fortify
foster
found
frame
freak out
fritter
frown
fulfill
fumble
fumed
fund
furnish
furrow
further
fuse

Word bank | G

gain
gallop
gather
gauge
gaze
generalize
generate
gesture
giggle
give
give rise (to)
glance
glide
glorify
gnaw
goad
gossip
gouge
govern
grab
grade

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | G (continued)

grant
grapple
grasp
graze
greet
grin
grind
grip
gripe
grope
group
grow
growl
grunt
guide
gush
gyrate

Word bank | H

hack
hail
hammer
hamper
handle
hang
harangue
harass
hasten
haul
head
heave
hedge
held
help
hesitate
hide
highlight
hightail
hijack
hike
hinder
hire
hit
hitch
hobble
hoist
hold
host
hover
humble
hunch
hurdle
hurl
hurry
hurtle
hustle
hypnotize
hypothesize

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | 1

identify
ignore
illuminate
illustrate
imagine
imitate
immobilize
impact
impair
impart
impeach
impede
implement
implicate
imply
import
impress
improve
improvise
inch
incline
include
incorporate
increase
incriminate
index
indicate
indict
individualize
induce
infer
inflict
influence
inform
initialize
initiate
inject
injure
innovate
input
inquire
insert
insist
inspect
inspire
install
instigate
institute
instruct
insure
integrate
interact (with)
interchange
interface
interlock
interpret
interrupt
intersect
intervene
interview
introduce
invade
invent
inventory
invert
investigate
invoke
involve
isolate
itemize

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | J

jab
jam
jar
jaunt
jeer
jerk
jest
jiggle
jimmy
jingle
jog
join
jolt
jostle
journey
judge
juggle
jump
justify
jut

Word bank | K

kick
kidnap
kill
kneel
knife

Word bank | L

label
lag
lambaste
lash
laugh
launch
lead
lean
leap
learn
lecture
level
license
lick
lie
lighten
limit
limp
linger
link
liquidate
list
listen
litigate
lob
lobby
localize
locate
lodge
log
loiter
lollygag
loosen
lose
lumber
lunge
lurch

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | M

maim	measure	model
maintain	mechanize	moderate
manage	meddle	modernize
mangle	mediate	modify
manifest	mention	monitor
manipulate	mentor	mosey
manufacture	merge	mother
map	message	motivate
march	methodize	mourn
mark	migrate	mumble
market	mimic	murder
massage	mingle	murmur
master	minimize	muse
maul	mix	muster
maximize	moan	mutilate
mean	mobilize	mutter
meander	mock	

Word bank | N

nab	need	note
nag	needle	notify
nail	negate	nudge
narrate	negotiate	nullify
navigate	nick	nurse
necessitate	nip	nurture

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | O

object
obliterate
obscure
observe
obstruct
obtain
occupy
occur
offer
officiate
offset
omit
operate
optimize
orate
orchestrate
order
organize
orient
originate
outline
overcome
overhaul
overlap
overlie
oversee
overstate
overthrow

Word bank | P

pack
package
paddle
page
pander
panic
parachute
parade
paralyze
park
parry
participate
party
pass
pat
patrol
patronize
pause
paw
peek
peel
peep
pelt
penetrate
perceive
perch
perfect
perform
permeate
persist
personify
persuade
petition
photograph
pick
picket
pile
pilfer
pilot
pin
pinch
pioneer
pirate
pitch
placate

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | P (continued)

place
plague
plan
plead
plod
plot
plow
pluck
plummet
plunge
pocket
point out
poke
polish
pore
possess
postulate
pounce
pout
practice
prance
pray
precede
precipitate
predict
preen
prefer
prepare
prescribe
present
preserve
preside
presume
prevail
prevent
primp
print
prioritize
probe
proceed
process
proclaimed
procrastinate
prod
produce
profess
profit
program
progress
project
promise
promote
prompt
proofread
propel
propose
protect
prove
provide
provoke
prowl
pry
publicize
publish
pull
pummel
pump
punch
purchase
purify
purloin
pursue
push

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | Q

quack	query	quit
quake	question	quiver
qualify	quicken	quiz
quantify	quip	quote

Word bank | R

race	receive	refine
radiate	reciprocate	reflect
raid	reclaim	refute
raise	recline	regain
rally	recognize	regard
ram	recoil	register
range	recommend	regulate
rank	reconcile	rehabilitate
ransack	reconstruct	reinforce
rant	record	reiterate
rate	recoup	reject
rattle	recreate	rejoice
ravage	recruit	rejoin
rave	rectify	relate
reach	redact	relax
read	redeem	release
realize	redefine	relent
reason	reduce	rely
reassure	reel	remediate
rebuff	refer	remodel
recall	reference	remonstrate

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | R (continued)

remove
render
renew
renounce
reorganize
repair
repeat
repel
replace
replicate
reply
report
represent
reproduce
repulse
request
require
research
resemble
reserve
resign
resist
resolve
respond
restate
restore
restrict
result in
resume
retain
retaliate
retort
retreat
retrieve
return
revamp
reveal
review
revise
revitalize
revolve
ride
ridicule
rip
rise
risk
roam
roar
roared
rob
rock
roll
rotate
route
rove
rub
rule
run
rupture
rush

Word bank | S

sail
salute
salvage
sample
sanction
sap
sashay
satisfy
saturate
saunter
save
saw
scale
scamper
scan
scare
scatter
scavenge

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | S (continued)

schedule
scoff
scold
scoop
scoot
score
scour
scout
scramble
scrape
scrawl
scream
screen
screw
script
scrub
scruff
scrutinize
scuff
scuffle
sculpt
scurry
scuttle
seal
search
secure
seduce
seek
seep
segment
seize
select
sell
send
sense
separate
serve
service
settle
sever
sew
shake
shanghai
shape
share
sharpen
shave
shear
shell
shield
shift
shiver
shock
shoot
shorten
shout
shove
shove off
shovel
show
shriek
shrink
shuffle
shun
shut
sidestep
sigh
signal
signify
simplify
simulate
single out
sink
sip
sit
situate
size
sizzle
sketch
skid
skim
skip
skirt
slacken
slam
slap
slash

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | S (continued)

slay
slide
slink
slither
slop
slow
slug
smack
smash
smear
smell
smuggle
snake
snap
snare
snarl
snatch
sneak
sneer
snicker
sniff
snitch
snivel
snoop
snort
snot
snub
snuff
snuggle
soak
soar
sob
sock
soil
solicit
solidify
solve
soothe
sort
speak
spear
spearhead
specialize
specify
speculate
speed
spell
spike
spill
spin
splatter
splice
split
splurge
spot
spray
spread
spring
sprint
spur
spurn
sputter
sputtered
spy
squander
squash
squat
squeak
squelch
squint
squirm
stabilize
stack
stage
stagger
stalk
stammer
stamp
stand
standardize
start
startle
state
steal
steer
stem from
step

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | S (continued)

stick
stiffen
stifle
stimulate
stipulate
stitch
stomp
stop
storm
straighten
strangle
strap
strategize
stray
streak
streamline
strengthen
stress
stride
strike
strip
stroll
structure
struggle
strut
stub
study
stuff
stumble
stun
stutter
subdue
subject
submerge
submit
substantiate
substitute
succeed
suck
suffer
suggest
sum up
summarize
summon
superimpose
superpose
supervise
supply
support
suppress
surmise
surpass
surrender
surround
survey
suspend
sustain
swagger
swallow
swamp
swap
sway
swear
swerve
swim
swindle
swing
swipe
switch
swoop
symbolize
sympathize
synthesize
systematize

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | T

tabulate
tackle
tail
tailor
taint
take
take flight
take leave
take off
take place
tap
target
taste
taunt
teach
tear
tease
telephone
tempt
tend
terminate
terrorize
test
testify
theorize
thrash
thread
threaten
throw
thrust
thwart
tickle
tie
tilt
time
tip
tip-toe
toddle
tolerate
tool
torment
torque
toss
totter
touch
tour
tout
trace
track
trade
train
trample
transcribe
transect
transfer
transform
translate
transmit
transport
transpose
trap
travel
traverse
tread
treat
trek
trend
trickle
trigger
trip
triple
triumph
tromp
trot
troubleshoot
trudge
trust
try
tuck
tug
tumble
turn
tutor
twirl

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | T (continued)

twist
twitch
type
tyrannize

Word bank | U

uncover
undergo
underlie
underline
undermine
underscore
understand
understate
undertake
undo
undress
unfold
unify
unite
untangle
unveil
unwind
update
upgrade
uphold
urge
use
usher
utilize
utter

Word bank | V

vacate
validate
value
vamoose
vanish
vanquish
vary
vault
vent
verify
view
vindicate
violate
visit
visualize
vitalize
volunteer
vow

Vivid Verbs

Word bank | W

waddle	weep	wiggle
wade	weigh	win
wail	whack	withdraw
waltz	whimper	withstand
wander	whine	witness
ward	whip	wobble
warn	whirl	woo
watch	whisk	work
wave	whisper	wreck
weave	whistle	wrench
wedge	whitewash	wrestle
weed	wield	write

Word bank | Y

yank	yelp
yell	yield

Word bank | Z

zap	zip	zoom

Vivid Verbs

Practice | your turn

1. Replace went in a calm scene and in a tense scene.

2. Revise "The author says the characters are different" using a more precise analytical verb.

3. Pick five unfamiliar verbs from the bank and write accurate sentences.

Vivid Verbs

Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Calm: wandered or strolled. Tense: rushed or darted, if supported by context.

2

Possible revision: The author contrasts the characters' responses to failure.

3

Check definition, tense, object and tone. Do not choose a verb only because it sounds impressive.

Source & editing note

Vivid Verbs to Enhance Writing.pdf | 6 supplied pages.

Source credited to Simply Novel in the supplied PDF. Concepts reorganized and condensed; repeated templates consolidated. Examples, practice and sample answers here are original additions, not copied student work.

Exact repeated list entries were consolidated and obvious extraction/spelling errors repaired. Alternatives may differ in meaning, grammar or tone.